
“ He felt **no doubt**, he would submit to **no defeat**, and he **took his army with him** as on a **whirlwind**. ”

A. F. WALKER, 11TH VERMONT VOLUNTEERS, ON SHERIDAN IN THE VALLEY CAMPAIGN

Scarcely bigger than a drummer boy, “Little Phil” Sheridan must have looked an improbable candidate to become, one day, general of the army. Of his contemporaries, the only others to attain this elevated rank were Ulysses S. Grant and William T. Sherman. But Sheridan was as combative as a gamecock in his love of a fight. He also possessed what Grant himself most admired, “that magnetic quality of swaying men which I wish I had—a rare quality in a general.” Soldiers responded to his presence and rallied at his command.

Pugnacious youth

Philip Henry Sheridan grew up in Somerset, Ohio, where town legend had it that he won every boyhood fight that came his way and even once chased his schoolmaster up a tree. But he was nearly rejected by the examining board at West Point because of his peculiar build. He was broadchested but tiny—his height was later generously estimated at 5ft 5in (1.65m). And the lanky Abraham Lincoln famously described Sheridan as a “brown, chunky little chap, with a long body, short legs, not enough neck to hang him, and such long arms that if his ankles itch he can scratch them without stooping.” West Point cadets, however, had to beware—Sheridan did not take kindly to teasing. Long arms made for a fine